Secretary of Defense weighed up MRBMs in Cuba and derived a different balance than his State Department counterparts: he emphasized deterrence while they emphasized diplomacy. Robert Kennedy and Dean Acheson differed over the lessons of history and the lessons that U.S. action in this case would teach the future.

In hindsight, the invention of the Ex Comm and its improvised procedures (including sessions separate from the President) gave men like these the very things they needed, under circumstances bound to minimize parochialism, strengthening their sense of common service to the top. But JFK's contrivance of a special hearing for the Air Force case before he ruled against an air strike at the start suggests that the Ex Comm had its limits as a forum, also as a court-of-last-resort. And in the second week of crisis there were signs aplenty that the third week might have witnessed something close to an explosion by harassed, frustrated, shut-out bureaucrats below the top. If so, their weary seniors, strained by thirteen days, scarcely could have contained them. As a means to meet the needs of second-level men, the Ex Comm was a travesty. Yet by the sixteenth day their needs would have been paramount. They would have had to mount the military operations and the corollary diplomatic actions.

Thirteen Days does not have much to say about the needs and frustrations of subordinate officials. It is a personal memoir and its author viewed the scene from a position close to the top. But the authors of this Afterword have heard in vivid detail the complaints of those below, also their hopes and plans. As one of us once told a Senate subcommittee:

> One can already see in these two weeks (of missile crisis) frustration rising at official levels. The…needs of officials in their own lives and work would have proven very intense indeed over a month. Two weeks were quite enough to build up great concern about being left out of things. At the same time, action officers were finding no department heads to take their issues to…. Then add to these psychological and operating troubles…that there evidently was beginning to be a proliferation of ad hoc subcommittees under the Ex Comm—and I think I can tell you what would have happened in the course of a month….